

also totally futile. The only ultimately rational attitude is to sit loosely in the saddle of life and to come to terms with the idea of chance as such.

Just as in life, so in the pursuit of 100-baggers. Good luck helps.

#10 You Should Be a Reluctant Seller

So, when do you sell?

In his book *Common Stocks and Uncommon Profits*, Phil Fisher had a chapter called “When to Sell.” He summed it up this way: “Perhaps the thoughts behind this chapter might be put in a single sentence: If the job has been correctly done when a common stock is purchased, the time to sell it is — almost never.”

That is probably right. There are certainly many examples where this philosophy in action resulted in riches beyond what seemed possible at the time of purchase.

On never selling, I think of the Astor family fortune. John Jacob Astor was the patriarch, and when he died in 1848, he was America’s wealthiest man. The estate passed to his son, William Astor. He grew the family fortune even further.

There is a piece of testimony, on some tax matter, before the New York Senate Committee in 1890. I love this bit of dialogue (which I included in my first book *Invest Like a Dealmaker*):

Q: You have just said that Mr. Astor never sold?

A: Once in a while he sells, yes.

Q: But the rule is that he does not sell?

A: Well, hardly ever. He has sold, of course.

Q: Isn’t it almost a saying in this community that the Astors buy and never sell?

A: They are not looked upon as people who dispose of real estate after they once get possession of it.

As I wrote in *Invest Like a Dealmaker*, “The key to the great Astor fortune — what gave it staying power and allowed it to multiply to such